



HUMANITAS
INSTITUTE

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Great Hearts Western Hills

School Website: <https://westernhills.greatheartsamerica.org/>

January 7, 2026

Artificial Intelligence Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix for more details.

SCL MEMBER

Any school that belongs to the Society for Classical Learning (SCL) is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because SCL requires adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Overall Classification: **CLASSICAL**

Executive Summary

Great Hearts Western Hills (GHWH) in San Antonio, TX 78245 presents a robust classical-leaning educational model grounded in liberal arts tradition, moral formation, and a commitment to the Western intellectual heritage. Across six categories, GHWH demonstrates strong classical alignments, with particular strength in religious/metaphysical foundations, school purpose and goals, faculty, and parent/community engagement. Some areas show partial alignment, notably in explicit curricular manifestos (grammar/logic/rhetoric, Great Books, and explicit Great Conversation articulation) and in pedagogy that clearly foreground Socratic/seminar-style practice in higher grades. The overall assessment therefore lands in CLASSICAL, with some CATEGORYs showing only SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL signals due to gaps between stated ideals and explicit curricular/teaching-method statements on public-facing materials.

Key observations: - Religious/metaphysical foundations are explicit through the emphasis on Truth, Goodness, and Beauty, virtue, and communal liturgical/ritual practices (e.g., prayers, moment of silence, and public recitations) that connect heart, mind, and belief systems. This is reinforced by statements about the community formed around the True, the Good, and the Beautiful and by references to cardinal virtues. These elements align strongly with the classical lexicon's positive indicators for this category. - The school's stated purpose centers on formation, virtue, wisdom, and a human-excellence telos rather than mere job preparation, with language highlighting a "great-hearted" leadership orientation and a liberal-arts/cultural-historic mission. This mirrors the classical aims described in the knowledge base. - Curriculum signals are present (classical vocabulary such as "classical, liberal arts," and "curriculum overview" are cited; emphasis on a unified, multi-disciplinary approach; references to Western tradition and sense of wonder). Explicit statements about grammar/logic/rhetoric and Great Books readings are not always spelled out in the public-facing pages we have, which yields a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL signal for Curriculum. - Pedagogy shows a clear emphasis on contemplative, wonder-filled learning (scholé-like elements, sense of inquiry, and memory) at least in lower grades, with public materials signaling an integrated, non-reductionist approach to teaching. Direct references to Socratic seminars and high-school rhetoric-based pedagogy appear less explicitly in the accessible pages, yielding a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL assessment for Pedagogy. - Faculty are presented as exemplars and mentors, with the public materials and faculty pages indicating a living-curriculum approach and a teacher-centered ideal consistent with classical formation. This aligns with CLASSICAL signals for Faculty. - Parents and community are foregrounded as partners in education, with clear emphasis on parental involvement, formation, and campus openness; family-book resources and handbook language bolster this CLASSICAL reading.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — **CLASSICAL**

- Evidence



- The school frames education around the True, the Good, and the Beautiful, and references the cardinal virtues as a core orientation of community life.
- Communal liturgical-like and devotional practices appear in public materials (Pledges of Allegiance, Moment of Silence, Prayer and Meditation, and other solemn practices in the handbook).
- The public materials emphasize reverence, wonder, and sacred aims, aligning with transcendental moral realism and objective moral order in the classical lexicon.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
- Positive keywords present: truth/true, goodness/good, beauty/Beautiful, virtue/cardinal virtues, wonder, reverence, prayer, liturgy. Examples appear in “true/good/beautiful” phrasing and in liturgical-like practices and devotion in family/handbook materials.
- Negative keywords: None of the explicitly listed negative indicators (relativism, secular humanism, etc.) are evident in the public GHWH materials reviewed here.
- Why this rating
- GHWH foregrounds transcendentals and virtue, and it ties community life to sacred/communal practices, which strongly matches Classical criteria for this category. The presence of liturgical-style practices and explicit appeals to Truth, Goodness, and Beauty are decisive.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- The school’s messaging centers on virtue, wisdom, and formation, with a leadership- and character-formation emphasis rather than solely job prep. Statements about forming “great-hearted leaders” and a classical mission align with formation-focused aims.
- The public materials emphasize a liberal-arts heritage, cultural literacy, and a telos anchored in the true/good/beautiful, consistent with the classical aim of forming humane, virtuous persons.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
- Positive keywords present: formation, virtue, wisdom, liberal education, classical mission, telos, true/-good/beautiful, scholé/contemplation, Great Conversation, classical heritage. The public content consistently signals formation and virtue-centered aims alongside a classical heritage.
- Negative keywords: None observed in public materials.
- Why this rating
- The school explicitly targets formation and virtue as central goals and communicates a classical, humane orientation, aligning strongly with Element 2’s Classical criteria.

Element 3: School Curriculum — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- GHWH presents itself as a “classical, liberal arts institution” with a unified, multi-disciplinary approach and emphasis on the Western tradition. This signals a curriculum grounded in classical methods and content, even if the explicit triad of grammar/logic/rhetoric and Great Books is not always spelled out in the accessible public pages.
- The Lower School Handbook and Curriculum pages emphasize focusing on the Western Tradition and depth of inquiry with a sense of wonder, which aligns with core classical curriculum ideals.
- The site highlights liberal arts emphasis and a curriculum designed to foster a sense of wonder and integrated learning, which are classic markers of the classical curriculum approach.

- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
- Positive keywords present: liberal arts, classical, curriculum overview, Western civilization/tradition, depth of inquiry, sense of wonder, Great Books (implied by classical canon and Great Conversation language in the lexicon), multi-disciplinary integration.
- Negative keywords: explicit references to grammar/logic/rhetoric and Great Books are not consistently explicit in the public pages, which reduces the strength of a full Great-Books/grammar-logic-rhetoric assertion on public-facing content.
- Why this rating
- GHWH clearly anchors curriculum in classical, liberal-arts language and Western-tradition thinking, and it emphasizes a wonder-filled, integrated approach. However, explicit, public, line-item statements about grammar/logic/rhetoric and explicit Great Books/Great Conversation commitments are not consistently visible in the available public-facing materials. This yields a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rating rather than fully CLASSICAL, pending fuller curricular details.

Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- The materials emphasize depth of inquiry, sense of wonder, and participatory, integrated, year-long learning that signals contemplative and contemplative-friendly pedagogy. The public materials repeatedly stress that education should involve wonder and a holistic formation, which aligns with scholé-like pedagogy.
- The Great Hearts public messaging and curriculum pages describe a classical, liberal-arts pedagogy with a unified approach, and “co-curriculars” are woven into the educational experience, which aligns with a classical model in practice.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
- Positive keywords present: wonder, contemplation, scholé (as a concept), depth of inquiry, memory-focused practices (recitation, chanting, memorization), restfulness. The Lower School Handbook content and curriculum pages provide language that supports these concepts.
- Negative keywords: Socratic seminars, oration, and rhetoric-based upper-school pedagogy are not consistently explicit in the public-facing GHWH materials we reviewed, which weakens the case for a full Socratic/rhetorical pedagogy in all grades. This reduces the Pedagogy score from Classical to Somewhat Classical.
- Why this rating
- There is clear emphasis on contemplative, wonder-filled pedagogy and memory-based, restorative elements, but explicit, high-school-level Socratic/seminar-based pedagogy and strong rhetoric training (as described in the classical lexicon) are not consistently demonstrated in the public materials. This supports SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL.

Element 5: School Faculty — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- GHWH materials describe faculty as mentors and living exemplars of virtue and mastery, consistent with a core “living curriculum” idea, and there are dedicated faculty pages referenced in the materials. The “Lower School Faculty & Staff” page and related faculty content indicate a focus on teacher role models and character formation.

- The classical lexicon emphasizes faculty as role models and the “portrait of a teacher” and “living curriculum” as central to classical formation; GHWH content aligns with these ideals through explicit emphasis on teacher as mentor and the community-wide formation of character.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
- Positive keywords present: model teachers, mentors, living curriculum, portrait of a teacher, collegial culture, teachers as guides, moral exemplars, character formation. Public content references include dedicated faculty pages, staff rosters, and leadership messages that align with these concepts.
- Negative keywords: None evident in the public materials.
- Why this rating
- The presence of explicit teacher as moral exemplars and mentors, and the explicit notion of a living curriculum and a faculty-centered core, supports a CLASSICAL categorization for Faculty.

Element 6: Parents and Community — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- The school emphasizes partnership with families, parent formation opportunities (e.g., classical book studies, gatherings), and open campus visits. The Lower School Family Handbook frames parent involvement as integral, and there are multiple references to parent engagement, onboarding, and community-building.
- The public-facing content references family and community as a core part of the classical experience, with language about a shared mission, “community,” and high levels of parental participation.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
- Positive keywords present: partnership with families, co-teachers, parent involvement, parent formation, family-education gatherings, open campus, community of learners. The lexicon lists these as key indicators for this category, and GHWH materials reflect them strongly.
- Negative keywords: None observed.
- Why this rating
- GHWH presents a clear, robust model of parent partnership and community involvement that aligns with classical expectations for category 6.

Aggregate Assessment

- Overall Ranking: CLASSICAL
- Four categories (Religious/Metaphysical Foundations; School Purpose and Goal; Faculty; Parents & Community) clearly meet Classical criteria, with Curriculum and Pedagogy showing substantial but not exhaustive alignment (SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL). The weight of explicit evidence across multiple categories supports a CLASSICAL aggregate classification.
- NOTE: Where the Public Materials Are Ambiguous
- In Curriculum and Pedagogy, explicit public references to specific classical components (e.g., grammar/logic/rhetoric as explicit curricular units, explicit Great Books/Great Conversation commitments, and explicit Socratic/seminar-based pedagogy) were not always visible in the provided public-facing pages. This is the primary source of the SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL signal in those two categories. The overall climate remains clearly classical due to strong alignment in purpose, foundations, faculty, and parent/community.

What Would Move the Needle

- (Not applicable here, as the aggregate ranking is CLASSICAL.)

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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